Lesson 29: Pronunciation: Connected Speech

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 3: Zero Waste

Adapted from Speaking, Listening and Pronunciation Projects for ELLs - Intermediate Level by Brittany Zemlick, Grossmont College (CC BY 4.0): 3.6 Connected Speech.

In this lesson

English speakers join words and change some sounds when they speak. This is connected speech. You will learn four rules: linking a final consonant to a vowel, saying two same consonants only once, /t/ that sounds like /d/, and d + y that becomes /ʤ/. Some of this is review from Units 1 and 2.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Link a final consonant to a vowel at the start of the next word.
- Say a shared consonant sound only once, as in "black coffee".
- Say /t/ between two vowels as a quick /d/, as in "a lot of".
- Change d + you to a /ʤ/ sound, as in "did you".
- Hear these changes when native speakers talk.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
connected speech	the way speakers join words and change sounds in natural speech	did you = didʒə
link	join the last sound of a word to the first sound of the next word	an apple = a-napple
final consonant	the last consonant sound of a word	the /k/ in "walk"
beginning vowel	the first sound of a word, when it is a vowel	the a in "away"
same consonant	the same sound at the end of one word and the start of the next	book club
sound change	a sound becomes a different sound when words join	matter = madder
/ʤ/	the sound at the start of "juice"	did you = didʒə
similar sound	almost the same sound, like /d/ and /t/	need to, sit down
native speaker	a person who learned English as a first language	Native speakers often link words.

Rules and explanations

Rule 1: Final consonant + beginning vowel

When a word ends with a consonant sound and the next word begins with a vowel sound, link the consonant to the vowel. Why?

- The final consonant will be easier to say.
- Your speech will sound more natural.
- Your listening will improve, because you will start to hear when native speakers do this.

Full form	Linked form
them all	thə-mall
an apple	a-napple
walk away	wal-kəway
(I'd like to ask you some) questions if (that's ok?)	question-sif
(Tell me a little) bit about (yourself.)	bi-təbout
(I) live in (San Diego.)	li-vin
(I have a younger brother) and an (older sister.)	an-dən
(I work) outside on (the farming plots.)	outsi-don
(What do you) like about (your job?)	li-kəbout

Rule 2: Final consonant + the same consonant

When a word ends with a consonant sound and the next word begins with the same (or a similar) consonant sound, say that sound only once.

Full form	Linked form
black coffee	blakoffee
one night	wonight
weather report	weatherəport

Rule 3: /t/ between two vowels = a quick /d/

When the /t/ sound comes between two vowel sounds, it sounds like a quick /d/. (This is typical of American English.)

Full form	What it sounds like
matter	madder
a lot of	əloddə

Rule 4: Final /d/ + /y/ = /ʤ/

When the /d/ sound (as in "did") comes before the /j/ sound (the y sound in "you"), together they become a /ʤ/ sound (as in "juice").

Full form	What it sounds like
did you	diʤə
read your	reaʤər

(The book prints "read you"; the r at the end comes from "your".)

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - In Arabic, a word never really begins with a vowel: there is a small stop (like a hamza) before it. If you put this stop before "apple" in "an apple", the words will not link. Move the consonant to the next word instead: a-napple.

Practice

Recordings: play the named clip from the folder `E:\personal-tutor\materials\library\esl-b1-speaking\attachments\03.06-connected-speech\` or from the book's web page (see Watch online).

1. Listen. Play `Listening_-_Sentences_from_Unit_2.m4a`. These are the six sentences from Andy's interview in Rule 1. Notice how the final consonant attaches to the vowel of the next word. Repeat each sentence.

2. Linking practice. Play `Linking_Practice.m4a`. In each conversation, find every place where a word ends with a consonant sound and the next word begins with a vowel sound. Draw a link. Then say both parts.

1. a. Where do you live? b. I live in San Diego.
2. a. What do you like about your job? b. I like working outside in the sun.
3. a. Do you have any pets? b. I don't own a pet.
4. a. Do you like to get up early? b. No, I prefer to stay up late.
5. a. Do you eat meat? b. No, I avoid eating meat.

Record yourself reading the conversations with your phone (or read part b while your tutor reads part a). Listen back: did you link the words?

3. Same consonant. Play `Listening_Practice_-_Linking_Consonant_to_Consonant_.m4a`. Listen and repeat the phrases: black coffee, some more, need to, good day, bus stop, sit down, book club, gas station

Complete the sentences with the phrases.

1. Thanks for coming. Have a _____.
2. I'm going to a _____ meeting today. I love reading.
3. I'm going to stop at the _____ before I go to work.
4. I _____ go to the store.

5. I like to drink my coffee with milk, but my husband prefers _____.
6. Can I have _____ cake please? It's so good!
7. Please _____. The show will begin soon.
8. The bus was very late. We had to wait at the _____ all morning.

Then play `Linking_Consonant_to_Consonant_.m4a`, repeat each sentence, and record yourself.

4. Video: Connected Speech and Linking (Elemental English). Watch it (see Watch online). Then answer True or False.

1. The goal of learning English pronunciation is to sound exactly like a native English speaker.
2. The goal of learning English pronunciation is to understand other English speakers, and to be easily understood.
3. English is sometimes difficult to understand because Americans speak fast.
4. English is sometimes difficult to understand because Americans connect words and change sounds when they speak.
5. English speakers use connected speech because they want to make themselves difficult to understand.
6. English speakers use connected speech because it allows them to speak efficiently and with rhythm.
7. When we speak, we connect the final consonant of a word to the vowel of the next word. For example: "drop it" sounds like "dro-pit."
8. When the final consonant sound of a word and the beginning consonant sound of the next word are the same, you only say that sound one time. Example: "book club" sounds like "booklub."

5. /t/ = /d/. Play `Changing_t_to_d.m4a`. Write one word in each space. Each missing word or phrase has a /t/ sound between two vowels.

1. Q: I'm going to a _____ on _____. Do you want to come? A: No, thanks. I have ____ ____ ____ homework to do.
2. Q: _____ _____ you doing? A: I'm _____ a _____ to my aunt. She doesn't use email.
3. Q: Would you like _____ on your toast or just jam? A: Just a _____ _____, please.
4. Q: Did you meet the new boss? A: No, I'm _____ her this afternoon.
5. Q: Would you like _____ or soda to drink? A: Just a _____ _____, please, but with ____ ____ ____ ice.
6. Q: Could you get the door please? A: _____ ____ minute.

Then record yourself reading the conversations. Change /t/ to /d/ between vowels.

6. d + y. Watch "Transforming d + y" (see Watch online). Then play `Listening_Practice_d_%3D_y.m4a` and complete the sentences.

1. _____ _____ you grow up?
2. _____ _____ help me please?
3. _____ _____ go?
4. _____ _____ close the window?

5. They _____ _____ yesterday.
6. _____ _____ hear what I said?
7. _____ _____ like tea or coffee?

Then record yourself reading the questions. Change d + y to /ʤ/.

Speak with your tutor

- "Read these phrases slowly, then at natural speed: an apple, walk away, black coffee, a lot of, did you. I repeat after you."
- "Ask me questions about my life, like 'Where do you live?' and 'What do you like about your job?'. I answer in full sentences and try to link the words."
- "You are a waiter in a cafe. Ask me what I want. I will order black coffee, a water bottle with a lot of ice, and toast with a little butter."
- "Invite me to a party on Saturday. I will say no and give a reason. Then I invite you."
- "Ask me five 'Did you ...?' and 'Would you ...?' questions about my weekend. Then I ask you the same questions."

Read aloud

- I live in San Diego. (li-vin) (↘)
- I have a YOUNG·er BROTH·er and an OLD·er SIS·ter. (an-dən) (↘)
- WHAT do you LIKE about your JOB? (li-kəbout) (↘)
- My HUS·band pre·FERS BLACK COF·fee. (blakoffee) (↘)
- I have a LOT of HOME·work to DO. (əloddə) (↘)
- Did you GO? (didʒə) (↗)
- WHERE did you GROW UP? (↘)
- Could you CLOSE the WIN·dow? (↗)
- WAIT a MIN·ute. (wai-də) (↘)

Watch online

- Connected Speech and Linking (Elemental English): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gAHUTKm_1n0
- Transforming d + y in English Pronunciation (Elemental English): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0rhfmtFrOWk
- The book's page for this lesson, with all the recordings: https://human.libretexts.org/Bookshelves/Languages/English_as_a_Second_Language/Book%3A_Speaking_Listening_and_Pronunciation_Projects_for_ELLs_-_Intermediate_Level_(Zemlick)/03%3A_Zero_Waste/3.06%3A_Connected_Speech

Answer key

2. 1 live in (li-vin). 2 like about (li-kəbout), working outside, outside in (outsi-din). 3 have any (ha-vany), don't own (don-town), own a (ow-na). 4 get up (ge-tup; the t comes between two vowels, so it sounds like a quick d), up early (u-pearly). 5 avoid eating (avoi-deating).

3. 1 good day, 2 book club, 3 gas station, 4 need to, 5 black coffee, 6 some more, 7 sit down, 8 bus stop. ("Need to" and "sit down" have similar sounds, /d/ and /t/.)

4. (book) 1 False, 2 True, 3 False, 4 True, 5 False, 6 True, 7 True, 8 True

5. (book) 1 party, Saturday; a lot of. 2 What are; writing, letter. 3 butter; little butter. 4 meeting. 5 water; water bottle; a lot of. 6 Wait a.

6. (book) 1 Where did, 2 Would you, 3 Did you, 4 Could you, 5 called you, 6 Did you, 7 Would you

My notes